

FALL 1898: AMERICA AT THE CROSSROADS

On August 12, 1898, the United States and Spain signed a preliminary peace treaty. Spain relinquished all claims to Cuba, permitted temporary U.S. occupation of Manila until the status of the Philippines was determined, and gave control of Puerto Rico to the United States. Almost overnight, the United States had an empire under its control.

In the four months that followed, U.S. and Spanish negotiators worked out the details of the final treaty in Paris. Of the five members of the U.S. peace commission appointed by President McKinley, four were backers of expansion. McKinley instructed them to take a firm stance, especially on the Philippines. By October, he insisted that Spain turn over the entire Philippine island archipelago to the United States. Spain was in no position to resist U.S. demands.

The final treaty, signed December 10, 1898, reflected McKinley's wishes. Cuba was granted independence, and the Philippines and Puerto Rico were transferred to the United States. McKinley agreed to pay \$20 million to compensate Spain for government buildings in the Philippines. The treaty was now ready for consideration by the Senate where a two-thirds majority was needed for ratification.

The treaty signing ceremony was overshadowed by an intense debate already raging in the United States over the issues addressed in the document. In many respects, the controversy touched on questions that were as profound as those raised by the clash over slavery or the arguments surrounding the writing of the Constitution.

Ironically, the Philippines—not Cuba—was at the eye of the storm. Before going to war, Congress had clearly committed the United States to upholding Cuba's independence. In contrast, the future status of the Philippines and its nearly ten million people had not been seriously addressed.

The treaty with Spain put the Philippines front and center. It called for Washington to "annex" the islands—in other words, to add the Philippines to U.S. territory as a colony. Opponents of imperialism were outraged. They formed the Anti-Imperialist League in October 1898 to defeat the treaty in the Senate.

The anti-imperialists contended that the creation of a colonial empire would corrupt America's political system. Under their banner, they assembled an impressive assortment of prominent Americans, including former President Grover Cleveland, industrialist Andrew Carnegie, and labor leader Samuel Gompers.

"We hold that the policy known as imperialism is hostile to liberty and tends toward militarism.... We insist that the subjugation of any people is 'criminal aggression' and open disloyalty to the distinctive principles of our government."

—Platform of the Anti-Imperialist League

Leading the fight for the annexation of the Philippines was a powerful coalition of politicians, businessmen, religious leaders, and military strategists. Within its ranks were Theodore Roosevelt, Massachusetts Senator Henry Cabot Lodge, and naval historian Captain Alfred Thayer Mahan. The most well-connected expansionists emphasized the economic and military value of imperialism.

"Americans must now look outward. The growing production of the country demands it. An increasing volume of public sentiment demands it. The position of the United States, between the two Old Worlds [Asia and Europe] and the two great oceans, makes the same claim."

—Captain Alfred Thayer Mahan

Within the imperialist camp, two distinct positions soon emerged. Proponents of what was known as the "large policy" urged the United States to compete with the European powers to build an overseas American empire. Meanwhile, backers of the "small policy" favored limited expansion to areas of significant strategic or commercial importance. As you will learn, all segments in the debate over the Treaty of Paris of 1898 would play a vital role in shaping the direction of U.S. foreign policy in the twentieth century.

"As long as the impression prevailed in this country that the Filipinos were fighting to throw off the Spanish yoke and seek American annexation, they were called patriots and martyrs, but when they demanded pure and unadulterated independence, they became a set of blood-thirsty barbarians."

—Indianapolis Recorder (black newspaper)

The Minneapolis Journal, 1899



"Wonder if he can see the point?"

A U.S. soldier confronts a Filipino insurgent with a "peace" treaty.

"We have been treacherous, but that was only in order that real good might come out of apparent evil. True, we have crushed and deceived a confiding people [the Filipinos]; we have turned against the weak and the friendless who trusted us; we have stamped out a just and intelligent and well-ordered republic;... We have debauched America's honor and blackened her face before the world; but each detail was for the best. We know this: The Head of every State and Sovereignty in Christendom...including our Congress and our...state legislatures; are members not only of the church but also of the Blessings-of-Civilization Trust. This world-girding accumulation of trained morals, high principles, and justice cannot do an unright thing, an unfair thing, an ungenerous thing, an unclean thing."

—Mark Twain

OPTION 1—FULFILL OUR NATIONAL DESTINY

Just as the courage of our founding fathers opened the door to taming the North American continent, the heroism of our soldiers and sailors in Cuba and the Philippines has revealed a new horizon of expansion and possibility. This is our God-given mission. We must grasp the empire that our brave young men have won and fulfill our national destiny. We have been chosen by God for greatness. We must look overseas, particularly to the Far East, to continue advancing. With their safe harbors and strategic location, the Philippine islands are the gateway to all of Asia. Of course, our role in the Philippines must go well beyond economics. Now that we have rescued the Filipinos from Spanish misrule, we owe it to them to bring the benefits of American civilization to the islands. Let us seize our national destiny and move bravely forward.

BELIEFS AND ASSUMPTIONS UNDERLYING OPTION 1

1. Just as destiny guided our nation across the North American continent, so it now points to expansion southward and eastward across the seas.
2. God has bestowed a special mission on the American people, choosing us to bring progress, Christian virtues, and order to distant and long-suffering lands. For the Filipinos, annexation by the United States offers them their best, and perhaps only, hope of creating a stable, effective government.
3. Our nation's continued prosperity depends on finding new markets overseas to absorb America's surplus production.

ARGUMENTS SUPPORTING OPTION 1

1. Establishing a U.S. presence in the Philippines will open new commercial opportunities in Asia, particularly in the vast markets of China.
2. Annexing the Philippines will block other countries from seizing the islands and converting them into a base that may threaten U.S. interests.
3. Introducing the American concepts of democracy and liberty to the Filipinos will eventually transform them into reliable allies.
4. Controlling the entire Philippine archipelago will ensure the security of Manila harbor and provide the United States with a strategic naval base for asserting our interests in East Asia.
5. In American hands, the Philippines will quickly emerge as a major exporter of sugar, cotton, tobacco, and other valuable crops.

FROM THE HISTORICAL RECORD

Senator Orville Platt, Connecticut

"I believe the hand of Providence brought about the conditions which we must either accept or be recreant [cowardly] to duty. I believe that those conditions were a part of the great development of the great force of Christian civilization on earth. I believe the same force was behind our army at Santiago and our ships in Manila Bay that was behind the landing of the Pilgrims on Plymouth Rock.... The English-speaking people, the agents of civilization, the agency through which humanity is to be uplifted, through which despotism is to go down, through which the rights of man are to prevail, is charged with this great mission. We propose to proclaim liberty in the Philippine Islands, if they are ours."

Senator Knute Nelson, Minnesota

"Today, in substance, the English government is as much a republic as our government. Her colonial development has served to increase the liberties of Englishmen.... That English government in British India, in Egypt, and in all other English colonies, wherever we look at it, has been a great improvement and a great blessing.... Are we incompetent to colonize, to develop, and to govern territorial possessions like England? Is the Yankee inferior to the Englishman? It is our duty under the providence of God to protect the Philippine islanders against anarchy, chaos and confusion, and the despotism that results from it. We owe them a duty now, as in the case of the drowning child snatched from a watery grave.... They are as unfit for self-government as most people on the face of the earth.... We are there for two purposes: to give the people of those islands a just, good, fair, and free system of government in some form, and to keep them out of the hands of the great powers."

Rand-McNally Bankers' Monthly

"Railroad building may be expected to boom in all the islands which fall under the influence of the United States. Our sugar and tobacco growing would receive an impetus. The forests may also be made to yield handsome returns, and in fact every industry so long under the blighting rule of Spain, will be exploited and made to show the advantages accruing from better government and wider enterprise."

The Churchman

"Woe to any nation brought to pass where it is called to guide a weaker people's future which hesitates for fear its own interests will be entangled and its own future imperilled by the discharge of unmistakable duty."

Railway World

"One way of opening a market is to conquer it.... Already our enterprising merchants are beginning to take possession of the markets which our army and navy have opened to them."

Senator Albert Beveridge, Indiana

"The Philippines are ours forever, 'territory belonging to the United States' as the Constitution calls them. And just beyond the Philippines are China's illimitable markets. We will not renounce our part in the mission of our race, trustee, under God, of the civilization of the world. God has marked us as His chosen people, henceforth to lead in the regeneration of the world.... We are not dealing with Americans or Europeans. We are dealing with Orientals. They are not capable of self-government.... Savage blood, Oriental blood, Malay blood, Spanish example—are these the elements of self-government?... The Declaration of Independence applies only to people capable of self-government."

"The power that rules the Pacific, therefore, is the power that rules the world. And with the Philippines, that power is and will forever be the American Republic.... The ocean unites; steam [powered vessels] unites us; electricity unites us; all the elements of nature unite us to this region where duty and interest call us.... Our fathers wrote into the Constitution words of growth, of expansion, of empire, if you will,

unlimited by geography or climate or by anything but the vitality and possibilities of the American people.

"Do you tell me that it will cost us money? When did Americans ever measure duty by financial standards? Do you tell me of the tremendous toil required to overcome the vast difficulties of our task? What mighty work for the world, for humanity, even for ourselves has ever been done with ease?...Pray God that the time may never come when Mammon [material wealth] and the love of ease shall so debase our blood that we will fear to shed it for the flag and its imperial destiny. The American people must move forward to the future of their hope and the doing of God's work."

"The White Man's Burden"



The Detroit Journal, 1899. (From <http://home.ican.net/~fjzwick>, Jim Zwick, editor)

Detroit News, 1898



Uncle Sam is shown babysitting his new possessions.